

Rubus fruticosus (Rosaceae)

Blackberry

Description Sprawling prickly shrub growing to 13 ft (4 m). Has palm-shaped leaves with 3–5 lobes, white to pale pink flowers and clusters of black berries.



Fruit

Habitat & Cultivation Native to temperate areas of Europe, blackberry is naturalized in the Americas and in Australia. It is commonly found along roads, in open areas, and in woodlands. The leaves are gathered in summer, the berries in summer and autumn.

Parts Used Leaves, berries.

Constituents Blackberry leaves contain tannins, flavonoids, and gallic acid. The fruit contains anthocyanins, pectin, fruit acids, and vitamin C.

History & Folklore As early as the 1st century CE, the physician Dioscorides recommended ripe blackberries in a gargle for sore throats. In European folk medicine, blackberry leaves have long been used for washing and staunching wounds. Arching blackberry runners that had rooted at both ends were credited with magical properties. In England, for example, children with hernias were pushed under arched runners for a magical cure.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Blackberry leaves are strongly astringent and may be used as a mouthwash to strengthen spongy gums and ease mouth ulcers, as a gargle for sore throats, and as a decoction to relieve diarrhea and hemorrhoids. Like many red or purple fruits, such as bilberry (*Vaccinium myrtillus*, p. 147), blackberry fruit and juice has significant antioxidant and anti-inflammatory activity, helping to maintain a healthy circulation.

Related Species See raspberry (*R. idaeus*, following entry).

Rubus idaeus (Rosaceae)

Raspberry

Description Deciduous shrub growing to 6½ ft (2 m). Has woody stems with prickles, pale green leaves with 3–7 leaflets, white flowers, and red berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and Asia, raspberry now grows wild and is cultivated in many temperate regions. The leaves are collected in early summer; the fruit when ripe in summer.

Parts Used Leaves, fruit.

Constituents The fruit contains polyphenols, especially anthocyanins, which have antioxidant and anti-inflammatory activity, pectin, fruit sugars, and acids. Raspberry seed oil is rich in vitamin E, carotenes, and essential fatty acids, and is increasingly used in cosmetic skin products.

History & Folklore In 1735, the Irish herbalist K'Eogh described uses for raspberry: "an application of the flowers bruised with honey is beneficial for inflammations of the eyes, burning fever and boils ... The fruit is good for the heart and diseases of the mouth."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Raspberry leaves are mainly used to encourage easy labor. While the specific mode of action is unknown, the leaves are thought to strengthen the longitudinal muscles of the uterus, increasing the force of contractions and thereby hastening childbirth. A decoction of raspberry leaves may be used to relieve diarrhea. The leaves also find use as an astringent external remedy—as an eyewash for conjunctivitis, a mouthwash for mouth problems, or a lotion for ulcers, wounds, or excessive vaginal discharge.



Raspberry leaves and fruit have been used since classical times as an astringent remedy.

Research A laboratory study in 2012 found that a raspberry fruit extract reduced joint inflammation, cartilage damage, and bone resorption.

Caution Do not take medicinally during the early stages of pregnancy.

Self-help Use Preparing for childbirth, p. 317.

Rumex acetosella (Polygonaceae)

Sheep's Sorrel

Description Slender low-growing perennial. Has arrow-shaped leaves and terminal spikes bearing small green flowers that turn red as their seeds ripen.

Habitat & Cultivation Sheep's sorrel is found in most temperate regions of the world. It grows in open areas and in meadows, and is gathered in early summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Sheep's sorrel contains oxalates and anthraquinones (including chrysophanol, emodin, and physcion).

History & Folklore Apart from its role as a salad vegetable, sheep's sorrel is an ingredient of an anticancer remedy known as *essiac*. A Native American formula, *essiac* also includes burdock (*Arctium lappa*, p. 65) and slippery elm (*Ulmus rubra*, p. 145). Western herbalists learned of it early in

the 20th century, after a Canadian nurse observed the recovery from breast cancer of a patient who had taken the formula. *Essiac* has since had a checkered history. Despite attempts to initiate proper clinical trials, none has yet been undertaken.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Sheep's sorrel is a detoxifying herb, the fresh juice having a pronounced diuretic effect. Like other members of the dock family, sheep's sorrel is mildly laxative, and holds potential as a long-term treatment for chronic disease, in particular that of the gastrointestinal tract.

Related Species Sorrel (*R. acetosa*) is a European relative that is also taken for its detoxifying effect. See also yellow dock (*R. crispus*, following entry) and Chinese rhubarb (*Rheum palmatum*, p. 126).

Caution Sheep's sorrel should not be taken by anyone with a tendency to develop kidney stones.

Rumex crispus (Polygonaceae)Yellow Dock,
Curled Dock

Description Perennial, growing to 3 ft (1 m), with lance-shaped leaves and many small green flowers arranged in whorls on the upper part of the stem.

Habitat & Cultivation A common wayside plant in many regions of the world, yellow dock thrives in ditches, on verges and in open areas, and barely needs cultivation. The roots are dug up in autumn, chopped, and dried.

Parts Used Root.

Constituents Yellow dock contains anthraquinones (about 2.5%), tannins (3–6%), flavonoids, and oxalates.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Though a valuable herb, yellow dock is not often used on its own, being combined with other alterative herbs such as burdock root (*Arctium lappa*, p. 65) and dandelion root (*Taraxacum officinale*, p. 141) for long-term toxic conditions. Its gentle laxative action makes it a valuable remedy for constipation, particularly when combined with changes to the diet such as increased bulk and fiber. By stimulating large intestine function, the feces are eliminated more efficiently, with reduced reabsorption of waste products, a form of toxicity that tends to occur in a poorly functioning colon. Yellow dock is also thought to improve the flow of bile, which further contributes to its detoxifying activity. It is also typically taken for skin conditions such as acne, eczema, and fungal infections, and for arthritic problems.

Research The anthraquinones are purgative and laxative (see *Cassia senna*, p. 75), but this activity is tempered by the tannins, which counter